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The Oil Manual | Europe

'Paper' vs 'Physical' Oil - A Short Primer

Dated Brent reached \$141/bbl last week while front-month ICE Brent traded at \$109/bbl. That unprecedented gap has prompted this short primer on the Brent complex: not “real” versus “paper” oil, but where scarcity shows up first and why prompt barrels now trade at such a premium.

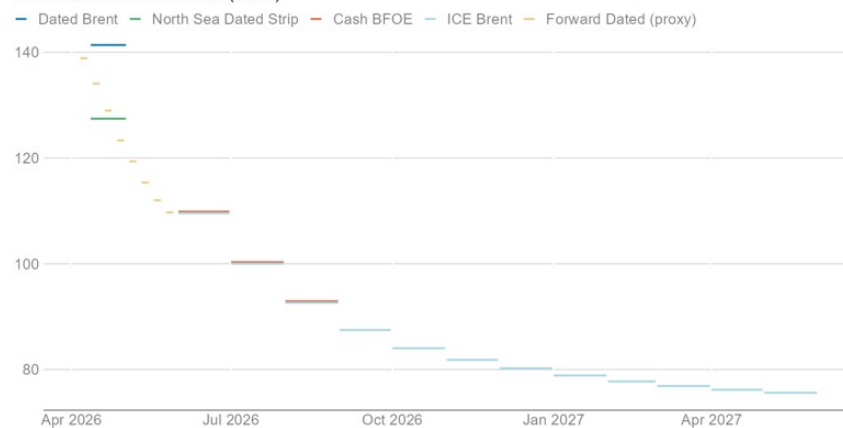
Key Takeaways

- The Brent complex is a linked system: Dated Brent, Cash BFOE and ICE Brent each price different exposures and will not always move together.
- The current blowout is concentrated in prompt Dated Brent; the largest stress is in immediate barrels and near-term Dated-linked instruments.
- The Cash BFOE-ICE Brent link still looks orderly. A small Brent EFP suggests futures remain closely connected to the forward cargo market.
- The real scarcity premium sits in prompt physical crude and near-term Dated exposure, as shown by CFDs, the Dated differential and the curve.
- This is not a paper-vs-physical disconnect. The current dislocation shows the Brent system identifying where the shock is most acute and immediate.

Exhibit 1: The backwardation at the very front - i.e. the most 'physical' part of the curve - is unprecedented

The Brent complex

Current forward structure (\$/bbl)



Note: Forward Dated proxy constructed from Cash BFOE + weekly CFDs
Source: Platts, Morgan Stanley Research

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Previous research:

- [The Oil Manual: Iran Scenarios \(23 Feb 2026\)](#)
- [The Oil Manual: Iran Scenarios - Updated \(2 Mar 2026\)](#)
- [The Oil Manual: Strait of Hormuz: Air Pocket \(16 Mar 2026\)](#)
- [The Oil Manual: Strait of Hormuz - Physical Air Pocket Arriving Now \(30 Mar 2026\)](#)

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The Brent Complex Under Stress

Why front-month ICE Brent can trade at \$109/b while Dated Brent trades at \$141/b

Brent crude oil prices have risen sharply recently, but not all parts of the Brent complex have moved by the same amount. Before Easter, front-month ICE Brent closed at \$109/bbl whilst Dated Brent already reached \$141/bbl. Such divergence is unusual - the typical spread between these two markers is usually no more than +/- \$3/bbl; not something most market participants need to worry much about. The current spread of \$32/bbl is an all-time high, which has led to commentary about “financial” versus “physical” oil markets, some of which is more confusing than helpful.

Against this background, we lay out how the Brent complex actually works, what different prices represent and how they can be interpreted. [Exhibit 4](#) shows this in a single snapshot: the Brent market is a linked system that consists of three parts - a prompt physical benchmark (Dated Brent), a forward cargo market (cash BFOE) and cleared futures contracts (ICE Brent futures).

Each layer has its own price discovery, which in turn gives rise to spreads between them. These layers are connected by a set of separately traded bridge instruments: the CFD, DFL and EFP contracts.

Each part of the complex captures a different pricing question. At the moment, the market is scrambling for prompt, refinery-usable barrels, and stress is appearing first in the part of the benchmark that is closest to the immediate physical problem. That does not mean the futures market is broken. It just means that different parts of the complex are pricing different combinations of immediacy, tightness and expected persistence. This note walks through that structure in eight steps.

Exhibit 2: The spread between Dated Brent and the 1st Brent future is usually small...

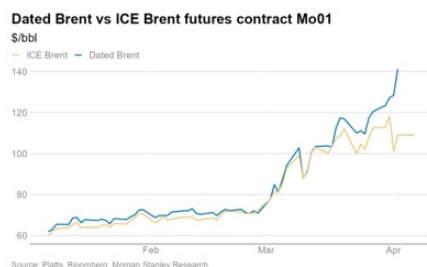
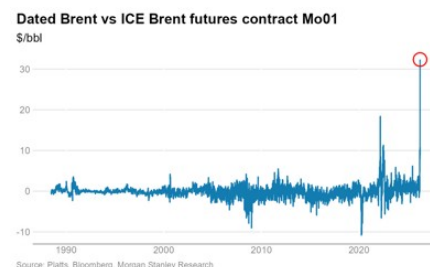


Exhibit 3: ...but this spread has blown out to its widest since the Brent market was created



Why can ICE Brent be \$109 while Dated Brent is \$141?

If front-month ICE Brent is trading around \$109/b while Dated Brent is trading around \$141/b, the spread looks so large that it almost invites the wrong conclusion. If both are called “Brent,” how can the gap be so wide? The answer is that the two prices are related, but they are not the same thing.

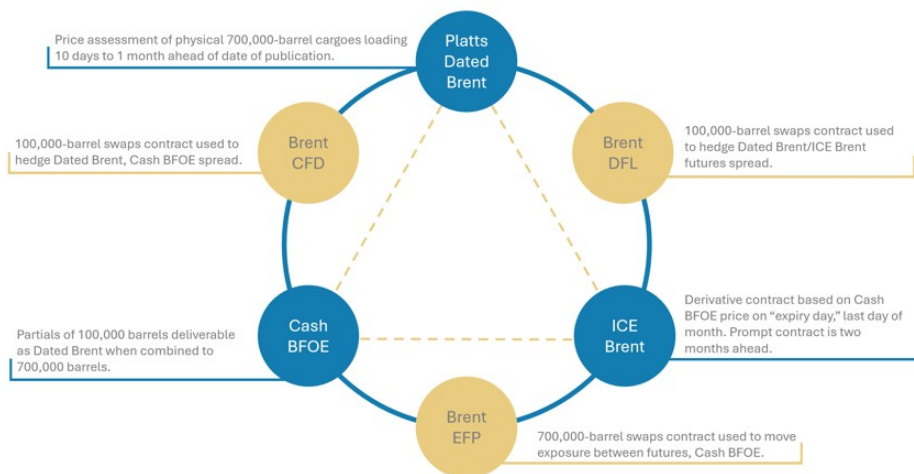
Dated Brent is the market's assessment of what a prompt physical seaborne barrel is worth in Northwest Europe. ICE Brent, on the other hand, is a standardized, centrally cleared futures contract whose final cash settlement is linked to the forward Brent cargo market through a defined expiry process. Those two prices are connected, but they do not measure the same exposure in time or at the same point in the chain.

That distinction becomes important in a shock like Hormuz. In our recent oil work, the argument was that the first phase of the disruption was concentrated east of Suez, but that the stress was now spreading west as Asia started bidding away Atlantic Basin replacement barrels and freight amplified the pull (see [The Oil Manual: Strait of Hormuz - Physical Air Pocket Arriving Now \(30 Mar 2026\)](#)). In that sort of environment the prompt physical Brent-linked barrels can move much more violently than the main financial contract.

So the issue is not really whether the market is tight. The issue is where, inside the Brent complex, that tightness should show up first.

In our view, the right answer is: first in Dated Brent, then in the instruments that bridge Dated to the forward cargo market, and only after that more fully in the futures layer.

Exhibit 4: The Brent Complex - How physical and paper trading intertwines



Source: S&P Global Platts

Dated Brent: what it is, what it measures, and why it is the physical anchor

Dated Brent is the physical anchor of the Brent complex. It is Platts' benchmark assessment of prompt physical light sweet crude trading for delivery from 10 days forward to one full month ahead. The term "Dated" refers to physical cargoes that have been assigned specific delivery dates or loading dates, rather than generic forward month exposure. Historically that meant North Sea light sweet crude. Today it reflects the value of the Brent basket — Brent/Ninian Blend, Forties, Oseberg, Ekofisk, Troll and WTI Midland — with Midland incorporated via delivered Northwest Europe pricing normalized back to an FOB North Sea-equivalent basis.

Two things are worth emphasizing from the start:

First, Dated Brent is not a single crude stream. It is an assessment framework. What it tries to capture is the value of the most competitive eligible barrel that can satisfy prompt refinery demand in Northwest Europe.

Second, the benchmark is designed so that the most competitive eligible barrel can set value for each day in the assessment window. That feature is central to how the benchmark works. It is what allows the complex to remain useful even as production of individual grades changes over time.

That is why Dated Brent is so sensitive to the relative economics of the grades in the basket. The outright Dated number is influenced by:

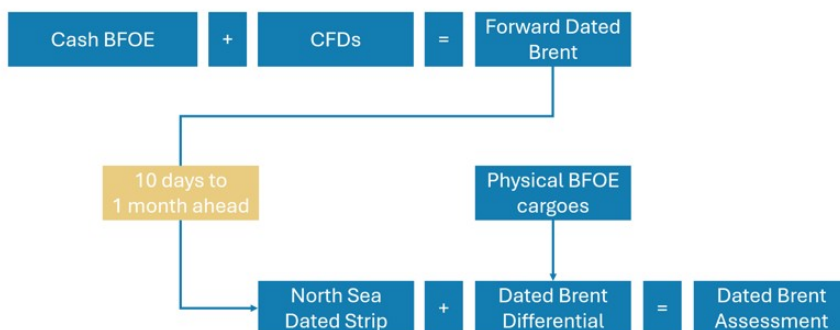
- relative pricing between Forties, Oseberg, Ekofisk, Troll and WTI Midland;
- quality adjustments across grades;
- freight and destination economics; and
- the loading-program determining which barrels are actually available.

WTI Midland's inclusion in 2023 reinforced that logic. The long-run problem for Brent was declining indigenous North Sea production. Midland added a deep pool of exportable light sweet crude, but it entered the benchmark in a specific way: Platts reflects Midland on a CIF Rotterdam basis and then nets it back to an FOB North Sea-equivalent value using freight, port fees and time adjustments. So Midland only competes inside Dated Brent after it has been normalized onto the same basis as the North Sea grades.

That is particularly important in the current market. If WTI Midland CIF Rotterdam becomes much more expensive because Asia is drawing Atlantic Basin barrels east, then the normalized Midland value inside the benchmark rises. That matters in the current market because CIF Rotterdam Midland has repriced sharply, so the delivered economics of Atlantic Basin replacement barrels are now feeding directly into the Brent benchmark. If the North Sea grades are also tightening at the same time, Dated Brent can move very sharply.

Dated Brent is produced through the Market on Close process. In practice, that means it is not just a simple arithmetic average of transactions. It is an editorial assessment built from bids, offers, trades and the structure of the market observed during the assessment window.

When people ask what Dated Brent “really” is, the best answer is probably this: it is the benchmark price of a prompt refinery-relevant seaborne barrel in Northwest Europe. In a physical shock, that is the right place to begin.

Exhibit 5: How the cash BFOE and Dated Brent assessments fit together

Source: S&P Global Platts

Cash BFOE: the forward deliverable cargo market beneath Dated Brent

If Dated Brent is the prompt physical anchor, Cash BFOE is the forward deliverable cargo market that sits beneath it. This is the point in the Brent complex where the market starts to move from prompt physical assessment into forward contractual structure.

Cash BFOE represents the forward market for the deliverable Brent basket. It trades in both 700,000-barrel cargo terms and 100,000-barrel partials. Those partials are important because they are the practical mechanism through which liquidity and physical deliverability are linked. If the same counterparties trade seven 100,000-barrel partials in the same direction for the same contract month, those positions can converge into a 700,000-barrel deliverable cargo. At the same time, not all partial positions end up as physical cargoes; on 'fallback day', partials that do not converge into a deliverable 700,000-barrel cargo are typically settled financially, which means Cash BFOE has both a physical and a financial aspect.

That convergence feature still matters, because it means Cash BFOE is not purely a financial market. It is a forward cargo market with a path to physical delivery, even though some partial exposure is ultimately settled financially rather than through nomination.

This is also where the structure can become less intuitive. Cash BFOE is more physical than ICE Brent, but less prompt than Dated Brent. It is the market for forward deliverable cargo exposure, not the market for the immediate barrel inside the Dated window.

That distinction helps explain a lot of the current confusion. In a severe supply shock, Cash BFOE can and should rise. But it does not necessarily have to move as violently as the prompt Dated market, because it is still one step back from the most immediate scarcity. It is a forward cargo month, not the next refinery-relevant barrel.

So it is useful to keep the division clear:

Dated Brent = prompt physical value
 Cash BFOE = forward deliverable cargo value

Cash BFOE is the base from which the market starts to infer forward Dated values. That is

where CFDs come in.

CFDs and forward Dated: how forward cargo prices turn into forward Dated values

Brent CFDs are the first important bridge in the system. A Brent CFD is a weekly swap representing the differential between Dated Brent and a forward month Cash BFOE assessment over the stated weekly period. Platts assesses eight weeks of CFDs ahead. The first weekly contract is the balance of the current working week between Monday and Wednesday; from Thursday onward the curve rolls to the following full working week.

One detail here is especially important: Brent CFDs are assessed relative to **Cash BFOE M2**, not M1. That means the weekly CFD curve tells you how much Dated Brent is worth, over each weekly period, relative to the second Cash BFOE month.

This is the logic behind this shorthand:

$$\text{Cash BFOE} + \text{CFDs} = \text{Forward Dated Brent}$$

That formula is a simplification, but economically it is very useful. Cash BFOE gives you the forward cargo base. CFDs translate that forward cargo base into a forward Dated Brent curve.

This is also one of the places where the current market becomes easier to understand.

In a shock like Hormuz, the prompt scarcity premium does not have to appear first in Cash BFOE M2. In practice, it can show up first, and much more violently, in CFDs. That is because CFDs are designed to isolate the value of promptness relative to the forward cargo market.

A simple example helps.

At the moment Cash BFOE M2 is \$100/b. The Week 1 CFD is +\$39/b, so the market is effectively saying that Dated Brent for that Week 1 period is around \$139/b. That CFD value is extreme - see [Exhibit 6](#) - but it shows the scramble for immediate replacement barrels rather than for generic forward cargo exposure.

CFDs are often where the market starts to price the premium for promptness. That is why, in the current environment, CFDs can move dramatically even when Cash BFOE M2 moves by much less. The weekly prompt premium is exactly what the CFD market exists to express.

Exhibit 6: The Brent CFDs have increased to historically high levels

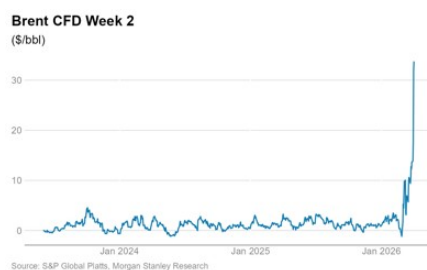
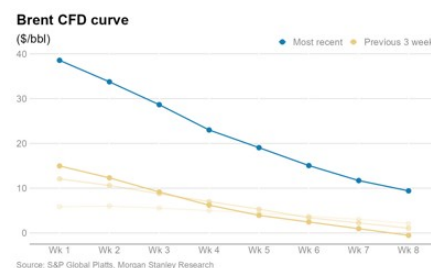
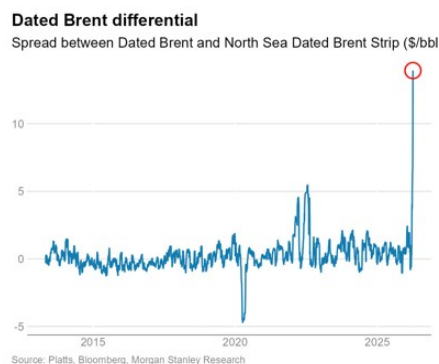


Exhibit 7: The CFDs have their own 8-week forward curve which is deeply backwardated



Dated differential and strip: how prompt physical richness shows up

Exhibit 8: The Dated Brent Differential is usually around zero but has also blown out recently



The next step is the internal decomposition of Dated Brent itself. Platts frames the outright Dated Brent assessment as:

$$\text{North Sea Dated Strip} + \text{Dated Brent Differential} = \text{Dated Brent Assessment}$$

This point tends to get less attention than it deserves.

The North Sea Dated Strip is the average value of the relevant forward Dated Brent curve across the North Sea assessment window, which typically runs from 10 days forward to the equivalent date in the following month. So it is not just one forward point. It is a strip average over the relevant date range.

The Dated Brent Differential is the premium or discount of prompt physical BFOE cargoes versus that strip. This is where immediate physical richness can often show up most clearly.

If the strip is already high because the forward Dated curve is backwardated, but the barrels actually loading inside the Dated window are tighter still, the Dated differential rises. That pushes outright Dated Brent above the strip. That is broadly what one would expect in the present market.

If Atlantic Basin barrels are being bid away by Asia, if freight is badly dislocated, if WTI Midland CIF Rotterdam is surging, and if Johan Sverdrup and other North Sea grades are trading at extreme premiums, then the physical cargoes inside the Dated window can become much richer than the strip sitting beneath them. That richness shows up as a widening Dated differential.

This also helps explain why the benchmark can look counter-intuitive to investors focused mainly on the futures screen. The outright Dated price is not simply the flat futures price plus an arbitrary basis. It is the combination of:

1. the forward Dated strip implied by Cash BFOE and CFDs; and
2. the physical premium of actual prompt cargoes versus that strip.

When both of those pieces are strong, Dated Brent can move to levels that look very wide relative to the futures contract.

That does not mean anything is broken. It more likely means the prompt physical part of the benchmark is responding first.

ICE Brent futures: what the contract is, how clearing works, and what happens at expiry

ICE Brent is the most visible part of the complex, but it is not the physical anchor. It is the liquid financial layer.

The ICE Brent futures contract is standardized, centrally cleared and margined daily through the clearinghouse. That means participants do not exchange the full notional value of the contract upfront. Instead, they post margin and then settle gains and losses through daily variation margin as prices move.

That structure is one of the main reasons ICE Brent is so liquid and so widely used by investors, producers, refiners and macro traders. It is easier to trade, easier to finance and easier to clear than cargo exposure.

The link between ICE Brent and the physical-forward cargo market is embedded in its expiry mechanism. However, that is more involved than many casual users assume. Open futures positions are not generally turned into physical cargo delivery at expiry. Instead, the contract is cash-settled to the **ICE Brent Index**. That index is designed to connect the futures contract to the prevailing value of the forward Brent cargo market on expiry day.

In broad terms, the ICE Brent Index uses five intraday sampling points. At each point it combines:

1. the second-month ICE Brent futures minute marker;
2. full-cargo second-month EFP trades;
3. first/second-month cash spread trades in Reference Quality Crude Oil;
4. independent market assessments of those components; and
5. any qualifying first-month full cargo trades close to the sample point.

So even at expiry the futures contract does not settle to “spot Brent” in any simple sense. Instead, the EFP - discussed in the next section - provides a mechanism that links the futures layer back to the forward cargo market.

That helps explain why front-month ICE Brent can lag a violent move in prompt physical Brent. The futures contract is liquid, forward-looking and financially cleared, but its settlement mechanism still references the cargo market rather than the immediate Dated barrel.

ICE Brent futures are ultimately tied back to the physical market, but that tie is enforced at the margin rather than across total trading volume. Paper turnover is vastly larger than the underlying flow of Brent-complex barrels, while the bridge back to physical oil runs through a much smaller EFP, cash-spread and cargo market. In normal conditions that is enough to keep the system aligned. In periods of acute prompt scarcity, however, Dated Brent and related physical indicators can move more violently than the futures contract, so pass-through from physical tightness into screen prices may be incomplete or delayed.

Exhibit 9: The Brent EFP briefly increased but is already back within its normal range

Brent Exchange of Future for Physical (EFP)
(\$/bbl)



Source: S&P Global Platts, Morgan Stanley Research

EFP and DFL: how futures connect back to Cash BFOE and Dated

The remaining pieces are the instruments that connect the layers.

EFP: the bridge between ICE Brent futures and Cash BFOE

The Brent EFP, or Exchange of Futures for Physical, is the instrument that moves exposure between the futures contract and the forward cash cargo market.

Economically, the EFP is the basis between ICE Brent futures and Cash BFOE. If a participant wants to move from cleared futures exposure into forward Brent cargo exposure, or vice versa, the EFP is the bridge.

That makes EFPs important in two ways:

First, they are part of the expiry plumbing. The ICE Brent Index explicitly uses second-month EFP trades as one of the inputs linking futures to the cash market on expiry day.

Second, they are an important live market signal. If EFPs widen materially, that suggests forward cargo exposure is becoming richer relative to futures. In other words, some of the stress is moving beyond the cleared financial market and into the forward deliverable cargo layer.

DFL: the bridge between Dated Brent and the futures-linked frontline

The Brent DFL, or Dated-to-Frontline swap, is the instrument used to hedge and price the spread between Dated Brent and the frontline Brent derivative layer.

In practice, the market often speaks about DFLs as if they were simply “Dated minus futures.” That shorthand is directionally useful, but it is slightly too loose. More accurately, DFLs are the main tradable bridge between prompt Dated Brent and the futures-linked frontline structure.

That distinction matters because it helps explain why DFLs are often the cleanest live signal of how rich prompt physical crude is relative to the financial layer.

If DFLs blow out, the market is effectively saying that Dated Brent is becoming much more expensive than the futures-linked frontline. In a prompt physical scramble, that is exactly what one would expect.

So the division of labour is roughly this:

- CFDs tell you how Dated relates to Cash BFOE M2 over weekly periods
- DFLs tell you how Dated relates to the futures-linked frontline
- EFPs tell you how Cash BFOE relates to ICE Brent futures

Taken together, those instruments are what allow stress to move from prompt physical barrels into the forward cargo market and then into the cleared futures market.

Exhibit 10: Similar to CFDs, the DFL has also blown out....

Brent Dated-to-Frontline swap (DFL)
Mo1 (\$/bbl)

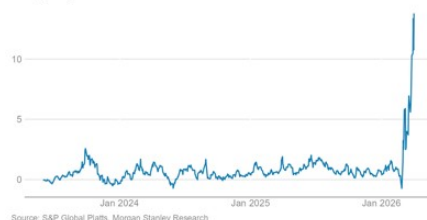
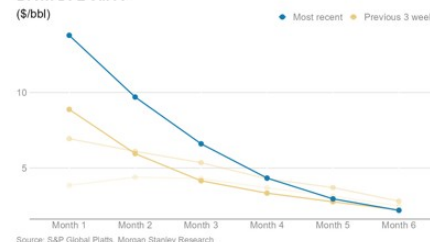


Exhibit 11: ...at its structure is also in deep backwardation

Brent DFL curve
(\$/bbl)



Interpretation: what the current dislocation is actually saying

The current dislocation is not best understood as a blanket separation between “physical” and “financial” oil. The more precise reading is that the stress is concentrated in the prompt Dated layer of the Brent complex, while the bridge between the forward cargo market and ICE Brent futures remains relatively orderly.

The clearest evidence is in the curve itself - see [Exhibit 12](#). Dated Brent is currently assessed at \$14.14/b, while the North Sea Dated Strip is \$127.4/b and the Dated differential is \$13.9/b. That means a large part of the move is happening inside Dated Brent itself: prompt physical cargoes loading in the assessment window are trading at a very large premium to the forward Dated strip beneath them.

A second part of the move sits between the forward Dated strip and the forward cargo / futures layer. The synthetic forward Dated curve declines from \$138.9/b in Week 1 to \$109.7/b by Week 8, while June Cash BFOE is \$110.9/b and June ICE Brent is \$109.6/b. In other words, the market is pricing an extreme premium for immediate barrels and near-term dated exposure, but a much smaller premium further forward.

That distinction matters. If the problem were a broad breakdown between the physical and financial layers, one would expect Cash BFOE and ICE Brent to be badly dislocated as well. Instead, the June Brent EFP is only \$0.3/b, suggesting that the futures contract remains closely tied to the forward cargo market. The real blowout is further forward in the chain: between prompt Dated Brent and the deeper forward structure.

Another way to frame it is that the headline gap between Dated Brent and front-month ICE Brent can be split into two parts.

- One part is the \$13.9/b Dated differential, which measures how rich actual prompt physical cargoes are relative to the strip beneath them.
- The other part is the \$17.4/b gap between the North Sea Dated Strip at \$127.4/b and the June futures / cash cargo layer around \$110/b.

So the current market is not just pricing higher oil. It is simultaneously pricing a very steep front-end backwardation in forward Dated Brent and an additional premium for the barrels actually loading inside the Dated window.

That reading also fits the broader market logic of the shock. The Hormuz disruption began as an east-of-Suez, prompt, medium-sour supply shock. At first that meant Dubai-linked

markets reacted more directly than Brent. But once Asia began bidding away Atlantic Basin replacement barrels, stress started to migrate into the Brent system. That migration is now visible in the places where one would expect it to show up: in WTI Midland CIF Rotterdam, in North Sea physical differentials, in Brent CFDs and in the Dated differential itself.

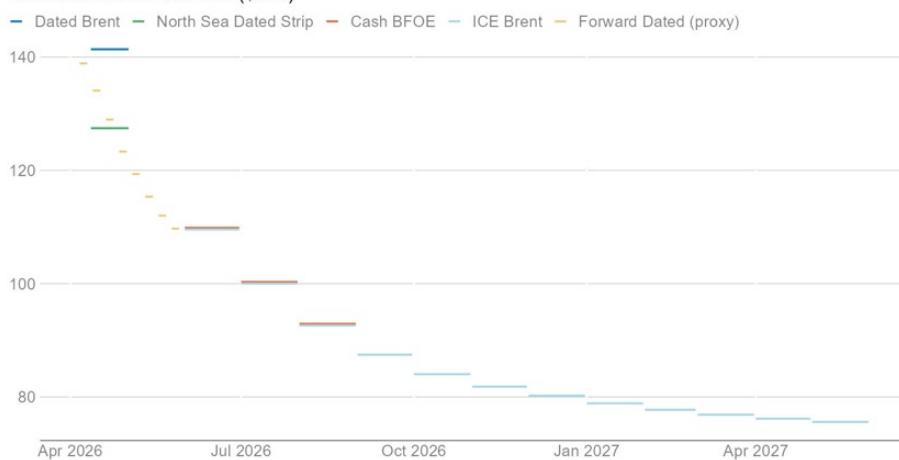
The weekly forward Dated curve helps sharpen that point. It does not stay high in a flat, uniform way. It falls from \$138.9/b in Week 1 to \$134.1/b in Week 2, \$129.0/b in Week 3 and \$123.3/b in Week 4 before moving down toward the low \$110s by late May. That is not the profile of a market repricing the entire Brent complex equally. It is the profile of a **market paying an exceptional premium for secure, refinery-usable Atlantic Basin barrels available now, while assuming that some of that scarcity premium will decay over the following several weeks.**

So the most useful conclusion is not that one market is “real” and the other is “fake.” It is that different parts of the Brent complex are carrying different parts of the signal. The Cash BFOE-ICE Brent link is still functioning in an orderly way. The blowout is concentrated in prompt Dated Brent and the near-term instruments that feed into it.

Exhibit 12: Combining the ‘physical’ with the ‘paper’ layers shows a Brent forward curve that is extraordinarily backwardated

The Brent complex

Current forward structure (\$/bbl)



Note: Forward Dated proxy constructed from Cash BFOE + weekly CFDs
Source: Platts, Morgan Stanley Research

Brent prices

Exhibit 13:

The Brent Complex

Latest value as per 02 Apr 2026 (\$/bbl)

Item	Symbol	Settlement/reference period			Value	Economic exposure
		Period	Start	End		
Cash BFOE						
Brent Mo01	PCAAQ00	M+2	01 Jun	30 Jun	109.9	Jun-26 BFOET cargo economics
Brent Mo02	PCAA00	M+3	01 Jul	31 Jul	100.3	Jul-26 BFOET cargo economics
Brent Mo03	PCARR00	M+4	01 Aug	31 Aug	92.9	Aug-26 BFOET cargo economics
CFDs						
Brent CFD Wk01	PCAKA00	Week 1	06 Apr	10 Apr	38.6	06-10 Apr prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk02	PCAKC00	Week 2	13 Apr	17 Apr	33.8	13-17 Apr prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk03	PCAKE00	Week 3	20 Apr	24 Apr	28.6	20-24 Apr prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk04	PCAKG00	Week 4	27 Apr	01 May	23.0	27-01 May prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk05	AAGLU00	Week 5	04 May	08 May	19.1	04-08 May prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk06	AAGLV00	Week 6	11 May	15 May	15.1	11-15 May prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk07	AALCZ00	Week 7	18 May	22 May	11.7	18-22 May prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Brent CFD Wk08	AALDA00	Week 8	25 May	29 May	9.4	25-29 May prompt Dated Brent vs Jul-26 Cash BFOE
Estimate of Forward Brent (based on Cash BFOE + CFD)						
Forward Dated Wk01	-	Week 1	06 Apr	10 Apr	138.9	06-10 Apr forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk02	-	Week 2	13 Apr	17 Apr	134.1	13-17 Apr forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk03	-	Week 3	20 Apr	24 Apr	129.0	20-24 Apr forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk04	-	Week 4	27 Apr	01 May	123.3	27-01 May forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk05	-	Week 5	04 May	08 May	119.4	04-08 May forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk06	-	Week 6	11 May	15 May	115.4	11-15 May forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk07	-	Week 7	18 May	22 May	112.0	18-22 May forward Dated Brent
Forward Dated Wk08	-	Week 8	25 May	29 May	109.7	25-29 May forward Dated Brent
Forward Brent						
North Sea Dated Strip	AAKWH00	10-M+1	12 Apr	02 May	127.4	12 Apr-02 May forward Dated Brent
Dated Brent Differential						
Dated Brent FOB Differential	AAXEZ00	10-M+1	12 Apr	02 May	13.9	12 Apr-02 May physical-vs-forward prompt premium
Dated Brent						
Dated Brent	PCAS00	10-M+1	12 Apr	02 May	141.4	12 Apr-02 May prompt physical BFOET cargo value
Brent EFP						
Brent EFP Mo01	AAGVX00	M+2	01 Jun	30 Jun	0.3	Jun-26 cash BFOE vs Jun-26 ICE Brent basis
Brent EFP Mo02	AAGVY00	M+3	01 Jul	31 Jul	0.3	Jul-26 cash BFOE vs Jul-26 ICE Brent basis
Brent EFP Mo03	AAMVY00	M+4	01 Aug	31 Aug	0.3	Aug-26 cash BFOE vs Aug-26 ICE Brent basis
Platts London 16:30 ICE Brent futures assessment (similar to CO and BCE tickers on Bloomberg)						
ICE Brent at London MOC Mo01	AAYES00	ICE M1	01 Jun	30 Jun	109.6	Jun-26 ICE Brent futures outright
ICE Brent at London MOC Mo02	AAYET00	ICE M2	01 Jul	31 Jul	100.0	Jul-26 ICE Brent futures outright
ICE Brent at London MOC Mo03	AAXZY00	ICE M3	01 Aug	31 Aug	92.6	Aug-26 ICE Brent futures outright
Brent Frontline derivative						
Brent Frontline Financial BalMo	ABWGA00	BalMo	02 Apr	30 Apr	109.1	Remaining Apr-26 average prompt ICE Brent exposure
Brent Frontline Financial Mo01	AAPQE00	Mo01	01 May	31 May	99.7	May-26 average prompt ICE Brent exposure
Brent Frontline Financial Mo02	AAPQF00	Mo02	01 Jun	30 Jun	92.4	Jun-26 average prompt ICE Brent exposure
Brent Frontline Financial Mo03	AAPQG00	Mo03	01 Jul	31 Jul	87.3	Jul-26 average prompt ICE Brent exposure
Dated-to-Frontline swap						
Brent DFL Financial BalMo	ABWFZ00	BalMo	02 Apr	30 Apr	22.8	Remaining Apr-26 Dated Brent minus Frontline spread
Brent DFL Financial Mo01	AAEAA00	Mo01	01 May	31 May	13.8	May-26 Dated Brent minus Frontline spread
Brent DFL Financial Mo02	AAEAB00	Mo02	01 Jun	30 Jun	9.7	Jun-26 Dated Brent minus Frontline spread
Brent DFL Financial Mo03	AAEAC00	Mo03	01 Jul	31 Jul	6.6	Jul-26 Dated Brent minus Frontline spread
Monthly avg Dated Brent proxy (based on Frontline + DFL)						
Dated Brent Financial BalMo proxy	-	BalMo	02 Apr	30 Apr	131.9	Apr-26 Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Mo01 proxy	-	Mo01	01 May	31 May	113.5	May-26 Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Mo02 proxy	-	Mo02	01 Jun	30 Jun	102.1	Jun-26 Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Mo03 proxy	-	Mo03	01 Jul	31 Jul	93.9	Jul-26 Dated Brent
Dated Brent Derivs						
Dated Brent Financial BalMo	BDLBM00	BalMo	02 Apr	30 Apr	131.9	Remaining Apr-26 average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Mo01	BDLM001	Mo01	01 May	31 May	113.5	May-26 average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Mo02	BDLM002	Mo02	01 Jun	30 Jun	102.1	Jun-26 average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Mo03	BDLM003	Mo03	01 Jul	31 Jul	93.9	Jul-26 average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk01	AAJNV00	Week 1	06 Apr	10 Apr	138.9	06-10 Apr average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk02	AAJOS00	Week 2	13 Apr	17 Apr	134.1	13-17 Apr average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk03	AAJOU00	Week 3	20 Apr	24 Apr	129.0	20-24 Apr average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk04	AAJOW00	Week 4	27 Apr	01 May	123.3	27-01 May average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk05	AAJPC00	Week 5	04 May	08 May	119.4	04-08 May average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk06	AAJPE00	Week 6	11 May	15 May	115.4	11-15 May average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk07	AALAW00	Week 7	18 May	22 May	112.0	18-22 May average Dated Brent
Dated Brent Financial Wk08	AALAX00	Week 8	25 May	29 May	109.7	25-29 May average Dated Brent

Source: Platts, Morgan Stanley Research

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(as of March 31, 2026)

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Stock Rating Category	Coverage Universe		Investment Banking Clients (IBC)			Other Material Investment Services Clients (MISC)	
	Count	% of Total	Count	% of Total IBC	% of Rating Category	Count	% of Total Other MISC
Overweight/Buy	1534	42%	461	50%	30%	698	43%
Equal-weight/Hold	1573	43%	372	40%	24%	716	44%
Not-Rated/Hold	4	0%	1	0%	25%	1	0%
Underweight/Sell	568	15%	89	10%	16%	209	13%
Total	3,679		923			1624	

Data include common stock and ADRs currently assigned ratings. Investment Banking Clients are companies from whom Morgan Stanley received investment banking compensation in the last 12 months. Due to rounding off of decimals, the percentages provided in the "% of total" column may not add up to exactly 100 percent.

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